Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

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THE TEERTH YATRA THAT COMES TO YOUR DOORSTEP



What if you were a devout worshipper of god but old, infirm or otherwise unable to visit a nearby temple, let alone make a pilgrimage?

If you were in Rajasthan, artisans of the Kumawat caste would bring the temple to you. Working out of Bassi, near Chittorgarh, they make objects of painted wood, of which the best-known is the Kaavad. This is a portable shrine with multiple folding doors, each of which unboxes illustrated stories, traditionally from the Hindu epics but also from myths and folklore.



Itinerant priests known as the Kaavadia Bhatt narrate the tales. The reading begins with the frontal panels following through to the inner ones till the story ends. The number of panels, usually between 10 and 16 hinged together, depends upon the length of the story.



Image: The Kavad Tradition, by Nina Sabnani

The last and central panel is opened to grant viewers a darshan of the deity or a view of the protagonist of the particular story. At the base of the Kaavad is a recess for offerings of coins or cash, as the audience chooses, just like at a temple.





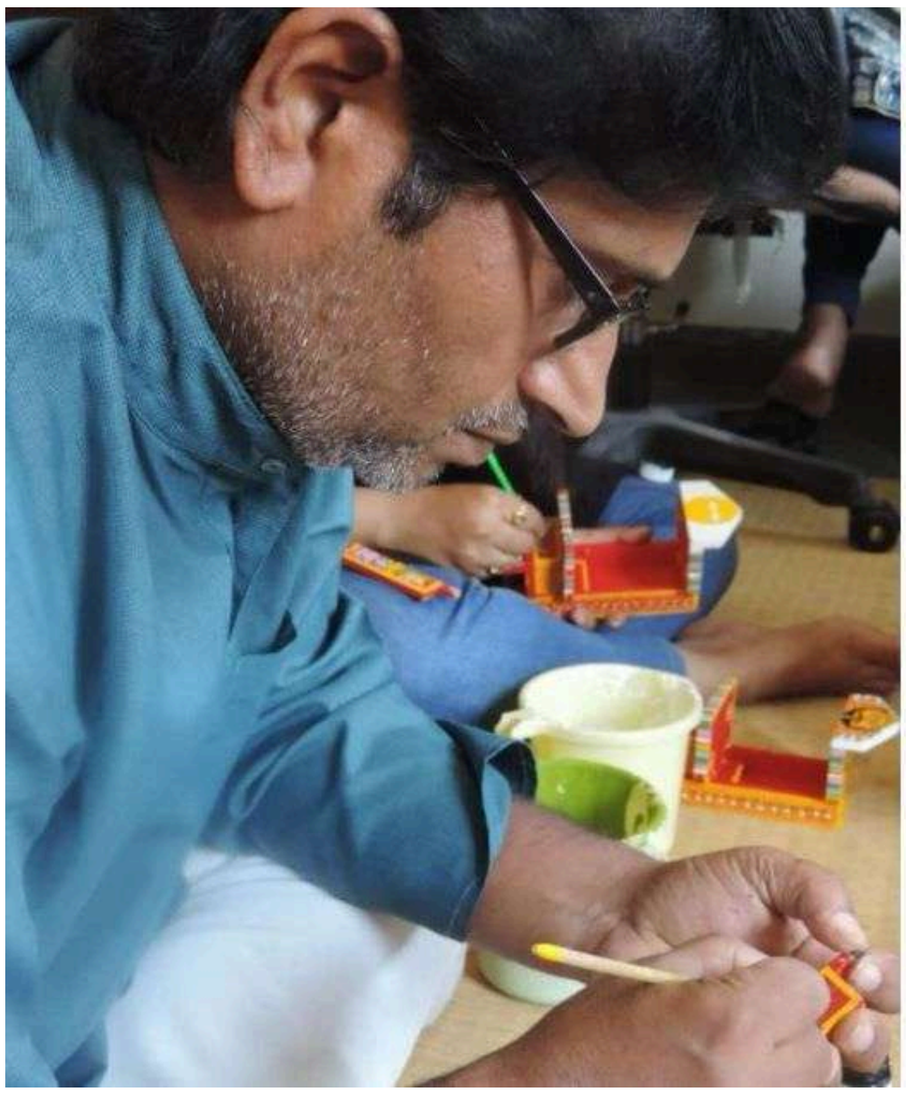
The story of the Ramayana unfolds....



... culminating in the inner sanctum.

The 500-year old art lost its relevance over the centuries but the perseverance of some artisans has revived it in recent decades. One of them, Kaavad craftsman 47-year-old Satyanarayan Suthar, won a National Award in 2014 from the former President Pranab Mukherji...







...for his exceptional work in keeping the ancient art alive.

During the Covid lockdown Satyanarayan discovered online marketing, and now sells to customers in Mumbai, Chennai, Bengaluru and Delhi, earning as much Rs. 1000 a day. He has since taken this art form to Singapore, Germany and as far as New Mexico, USA.



An interesting footnote: While the 500-year old Kaavad art was originally designed for illustrating the ancient epics, contemporary Kaavad artisans have expanded their content. They now include informal education on subjects like the freedom movement and its leaders, famous monuments, simple primary education, rights of the girl child ('Beti bachao, Beti padhao') and recently, even wedding invitations with the genealogical background of the two families!

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